

Veterans Backbone Raising Concerns Policy

Purpose

The purpose of this policy is to ensure that concerns relating to safety, wellbeing, safeguarding, conduct, risk, or organisational practice are raised, reviewed, and managed appropriately.

Veterans Backbone is committed to creating a culture where people feel able to speak up without fear of retaliation, dismissal, or blame.

Scope

This policy applies to:

- Veterans and participants
- Residents
- Staff
- Volunteers
- Trustees
- Contractors
- External professionals
- Visitors
- Partner organisations

Policy Statement

Concerns should be raised as early as possible.

Veterans Backbone believes that identifying and addressing concerns early helps prevent harm, protects individuals, and strengthens organisational integrity.

No person should be discouraged from raising a genuine concern.

What Is A Concern?

Examples include:

- Safeguarding concerns
- Welfare concerns
- Risk of harm
- Boundary breaches
- Professional misconduct
- Bullying or harassment
- Abuse or neglect
- Discrimination
- Unsafe practices
- Serious policy breaches

- Criminal activity
- Conflicts of interest
- Organisational integrity concerns

This list is not exhaustive.

Immediate Risk Situations

Where there is an immediate risk to life or safety:

- Emergency services should be contacted immediately where appropriate.
- Immediate safeguarding action should be taken.
- Relevant personnel should be informed as soon as reasonably possible.

Safety always takes priority.

Confidentiality

Concerns will be handled as confidentially as possible.

However, confidentiality cannot be guaranteed where:

- Safeguarding concerns exist
- Criminal activity is suspected
- Information sharing is required to prevent harm
- Legal obligations apply

Anonymous Concerns

Anonymous concerns may be accepted and reviewed.

However, anonymity may limit the ability to investigate fully or provide feedback.

Investigation & Review

Concerns will be reviewed proportionately based on:

- Nature of concern
- Level of risk
- Available evidence
- Potential impact

Investigations may involve:

- Information gathering
- Interviews
- Record reviews
- Safeguarding assessment
- External agency involvement

Outcomes

Outcomes may include:

- No further action
- Additional support
- Informal resolution
- Training or supervision
- Safeguarding intervention
- Formal investigation
- Disciplinary action
- Referral to external agencies

Protection From Retaliation

No person should suffer disadvantage for raising a genuine concern in good faith.

Retaliation against individuals who raise concerns may itself be treated as a serious concern.

Record Keeping

All concerns should be recorded appropriately and retained in accordance with organisational record management requirements.

Review

This policy will be reviewed annually or following significant incidents, safeguarding concerns, or organisational learning.